



# BRAZIL



THE LARGEST COUNTRY in South America, Brazil is a land of opposites. Watered by the second longest river in the world, the Amazon, it has the world's largest rainforest, arid deserts in the northeast, and rolling grassland in the south. Crowded cities contrast with remote areas that have never been explored. The country has many well-developed industries and a huge, successful agricultural base, but many people live in poverty. Brazilian society is a vibrant, diverse mix of cultures.

## Physical features

The Amazon Basin and its forests, some mountainous, occupy northern Brazil. The southeast is a region of plateaus that vary from sunburnt arid scrublands to rich fields and pastures.



### Highlands

The Brazilian Highlands extend from the Amazon Basin to the coast, rising to 3,000 m (10,000 ft). About 60 per cent of the country is dominated by the plateau, where landscape ranges from tropical forest to dry, rocky desert.

## BRAZIL FACTS

|                   |                                         |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY      | Brasília                                |
| AREA              | 8,511,970 sq km<br>(3,286,472 sq miles) |
| POPULATION        | 170,000,000                             |
| MAIN LANGUAGE     | Portuguese                              |
| MAJOR RELIGION    | Christian                               |
| CURRENCY          | Réal                                    |
| LIFE EXPECTANCY   | 68 years                                |
| PEOPLE PER DOCTOR | 769                                     |
| GOVERNMENT        | Multi-party democracy                   |
| ADULT LITERACY    | 85%                                     |



### Amazonian rainforest

Around half of Brazil is cloaked in dense rainforest. The River Amazon, 6,448 km (4,007 miles) long, runs through the north of Brazil, giving life to more than 40,000 different species of plants and animals in the forests.

41°C (106°F)      -4°C (25°F)

18°C (64°F)      22°C (72°F)

1,600 mm (63 in)

### Climate

All except the extreme south of Brazil lies in the tropics, so temperatures are always high. The Amazonian rainforest receives about 4,000 mm (157 in) every year. By contrast, droughts are common in the northeast corner. Farther south, summers are hot and winters can be cold with frosts.



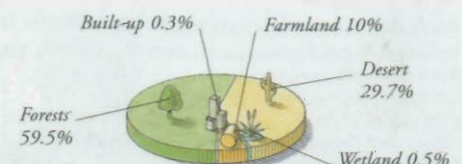
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## Brasília

Brazil's modern capital city, Brasília, lies on the extreme northern edge of the plateau region. Purpose-built in the 1950s on the site of a felled rainforest, the city replaced Rio de Janeiro as capital. Its inland position has helped to develop new areas away from the coast. There are many imaginative, futuristic buildings, including the spectacular cathedral.



Brasília Cathedral



### Land use

Thick forests covers the majority of the land, but are being cleared at an alarming rate to make way for farmland and roads. The fertile southeast, especially around São Paulo, is permanently farmed. Much of the land is desert.